

“WE ARE 50 OR 100 YEARS BEHIND THE ADVANCED COUNTRIES. WE MUST MAKE GOOD THIS DISTANCE IN TEN YEARS.”

Josef Stalin, in a speech to the first All-Union Conference of leading personnel of Socialist Industry, February 4, 1931

IN THE EARLY MONTHS OF 1930, THE SOVIET UNION was thrown into turmoil by the mass **collectivization of agriculture**—the replacement of privately owned peasant farms with large, state-run farming practices. In the eyes of dictator Joseph Stalin (see 1928), who wanted to transform the Soviet Union into a modern industrial state, small-scale peasant agriculture was an obstacle to be ruthlessly swept aside—both inefficient and tainted with antisocialist self-interest. The peasants, however, were ferociously attached to their land and farm animals, and when communist officials were sent to villages to organize collective farms, they met **widespread resistance**. Peasants slaughtered

their animals rather than hand them over to the state, and attacked the communists with stones and clubs. The authorities responded with **mass arrests of “kulaks”**—better-off peasants—and troublemakers. By March it was announced that 14 million Soviet farms had been collectivized, but the chaos it created was so disruptive to food production that Stalin had to order a pause in the campaign.

It was no coincidence that the following month an agency known as the **Gulag was set up** to run a system of forced labor camps across the Soviet Union. Of about one million peasants arrested in the early 1930s, hundreds of thousands ended up in Gulag camps, providing

slave labor to drive the developing Soviet economy.

Collectivization failed to produce an increase in agricultural output, and the vision of vast Soviet prairies farmed by tractors and mechanical harvesters remained largely a fantasy; instead there was famine (see 1933). But it did stimulate a mass movement of peasants to the cities, where they found work on construction sites and in factories. **Soviet industrial projects**, many using Gulag prison labor, developed on a vast scale, while the rest of the world plunged into an economic recession.

In **India** the wily and charismatic Mohandas Gandhi (see panel, right) was mounting a campaign of **civil disobedience** against British rule. Gandhi dramatized his opposition to the government salt monopoly by staging a march



Unemployed men waiting for food handouts in New York during the Depression. There was no federal unemployment benefit or welfare in the US.



MOHANDAS GANDHI
(1869–1948)

Known as Mahatma (“Great Soul”), Gandhi was born into a privileged Indian family and studied law in London. His first campaigns of non-violent civil disobedience were in South Africa. Returning to India in 1915 he led the opposition to British rule, although many nationalists rejected his non-violence. In 1948 he was assassinated by Hindu extremists, outraged by his conciliatory attitude toward Muslims.

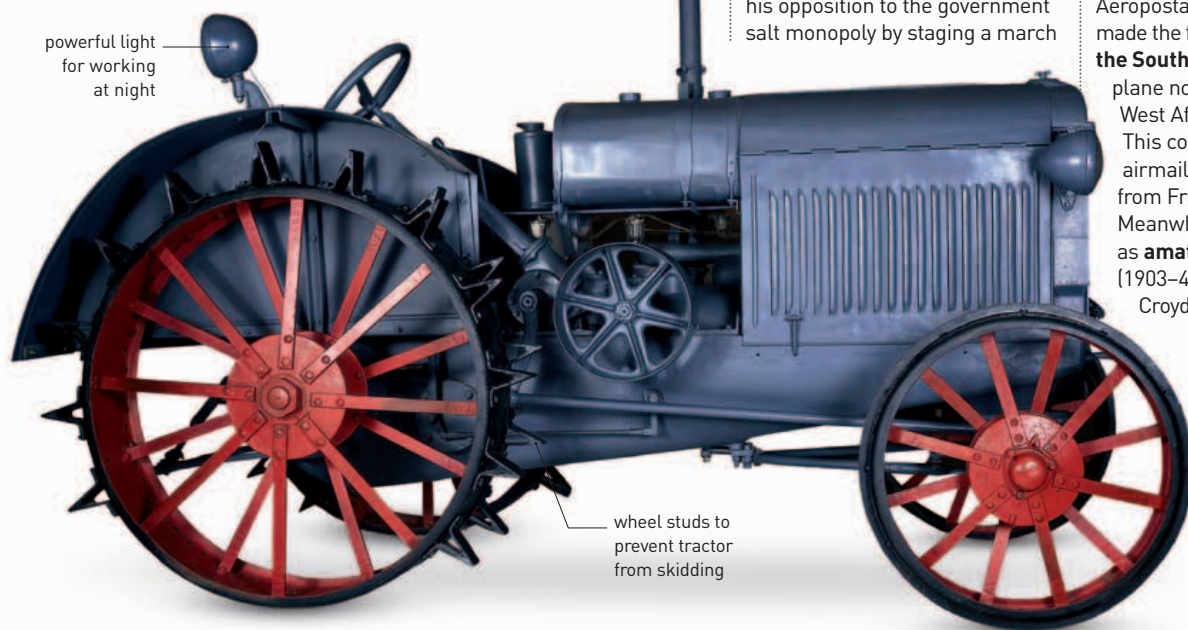
from Ahmedabad to the Indian Ocean. Setting out on March 12, he reached the sea on April 6, and scooped up a handful of salt water in public defiance of the government’s ban on unlicensed salt gathering. Although Gandhi advocated strict nonviolence, the **Salt March triggered riots** that redoubled after his arrest on May 5. Despite this, the British remained committed to gradually extending India’s limited self-government.

The exploits of adventurous **aviators** continued to fascinate the public, as they had done through the 1920s. Pilots became national heroes through pioneering **long-distance flights**. In May, Jean Mermoz (1901–36), who was employed by the French Aéropostale airmail company, made the first **postal flight across the South Atlantic**, flying a float plane nonstop from Dakar in West Africa to Natal in Brazil. This completed an unbroken airmail link that stretched from France to Chile. Meanwhile, the British cheered as **amateur pilot Amy Johnson** (1903–41) flew solo from Croydon in England to Darwin,

Australia in a second-hand De Havilland Gypsy Moth biplane. The journey, which took 19 days, was especially remarkable since she had never even flown across the English Channel.

This amateur triumph of British aviation stood in stark contrast with the fate of an expensive government project, the **R101 airship**. On its maiden voyage in October, R101 was intended to

powerful light
for working
at night



wheel studs to
prevent tractor
from skidding

Soviet tractor

By the 1930s the Soviet Union was manufacturing its own tractors. There were about 200,000 tractors in the Soviet Union by 1934.

